

Eudocimus ruber

Scarlet ibis

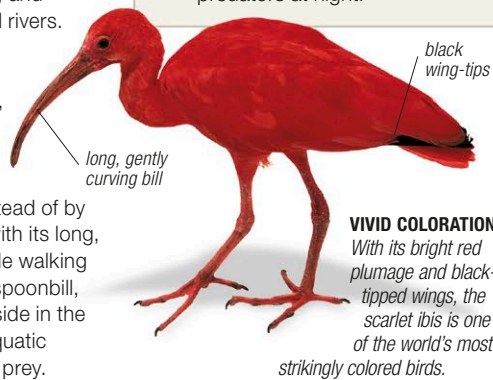


Location S. Central America, N. and E. South America
Status Least concern

Length 22–27 in (56–68 cm)
Weight 28–33 oz (775–925 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant



This vividly colored bird gathers in large flocks—sometimes of tens of thousands of birds—in the breeding season, on the coastal wetlands of northern South America, in swamps, lagoons, and mangroves, as well as on tidal rivers. Birds of a colony pair off for breeding (although they often mate with other partners, too), building their nests in trees close to water. Like other ibises, the scarlet ibis finds its food primarily by touch instead of by sight, probing into soft mud with its long, gently curving bill, usually while walking along. It may also feed like a spoonbill, sweeping its bill from side to side in the water. Crabs, shellfish, and aquatic insects are the major items of prey.



VIVID COLORATION
With its bright red plumage and black-tipped wings, the scarlet ibis is one of the world's most strikingly colored birds.

TREETOP ROOST



The scarlet ibis feeds on the ground during daytime, but at dusk, it flies up into waterside trees to roost. This behavior—common among ibises, herons, and their relatives—reduces the danger of being attacked by predators at night.

Scopus umbretta

Hamerkop



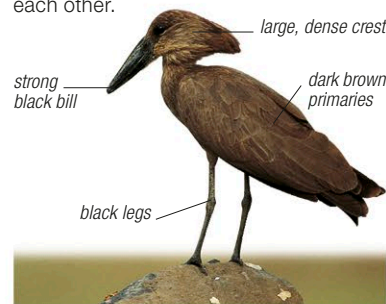
Location Africa (south of Sahara), Madagascar, S.W. Asia
Status Least concern

Length 16–22 in (40–56 cm)
Weight 15 oz (425 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant



From the German “hammerkopf” meaning hammerhead, this bird’s common name is a good description of its unusual shape, with its relatively short bill and heavy crest on the back of its head. Dull brown, it has darker brown primary feathers, and a paler chin and throat. While many waterbirds feed primarily on fish, the hamerkop’s

main diet consists of amphibians. It feeds in shallow water, using its bill to rake the bottom for frogs and fish; it also flies above groups of tadpoles and snatches them up. The hamerkop builds the largest roofed nest of any bird. Made of twigs, mud, and grass, it is oven-shaped with an entrance tunnel, up to 6½ ft (2 m) across and deep, and sited high up in a tree. While the hamerkop breeds solitarily, nests are often found near each other.



Balaeniceps rex

Shoebill



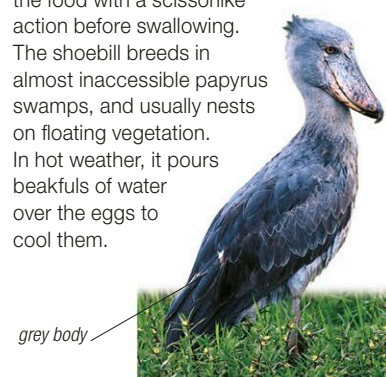
Location Central Africa
Status Vulnerable

Height 3½–4½ ft (1.1–1.4 m)
Weight 10–14 lb (4.5–6.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant



The shoebill, or whale-headed stork, has a highly distinctive, large, broad, clog-shaped bill. It often hunts for prey in pools that are drying out, feeding mainly on lungfish, and also on frogs and small

mammals. The shoebill frequently adopts an unusual method of hunting: it plunges on prey as if falling on it and then cuts up the food with a scissorlike action before swallowing. The shoebill breeds in almost inaccessible papyrus swamps, and usually nests on floating vegetation. In hot weather, it pours beakfuls of water over the eggs to cool them.



Platalea alba

African spoonbill



Location Africa (south of Sahara), Madagascar
Status Least concern

Length 30–35½ in (75–90 cm)
Weight 4½ lb (2 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant



This graceful, red-legged white bird belongs to a group of 6 species that get their name from the broad,

spoon-shaped tips of their bills. Like its relatives, it swings its bill from side to side in the water, creating currents that bring fish within range, which the spoonbill speedily snaps up. It may also feed by night, looking for fish and running after them in a sprint.



Pelecanus crispus

Dalmatian pelican

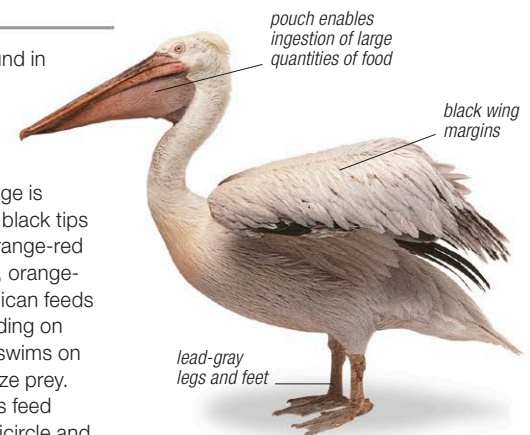


Location S.E. Europe, S. and S.W. Asia, N.E. Africa
Status Vulnerable

Length 5¼–6 ft (1.6–1.8 m)
Weight 22–29 lb (10–13 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant



This pelican is the largest found in Europe. Despite its size and weight, it is a strong flier, soaring high up during migration on its very large, broad wings. Its plumage is essentially silvery white, with black tips to the wings, and it has an orange-red pouch beneath a pale yellow, orange-tipped bill. The Dalmatian pelican feeds on a wide variety of fish, needing on average 2¼ lb (1 kg) a day. It swims on the surface, up-ending to seize prey. Sometimes a number of birds feed cooperatively, forming a semicircle and



Pelecanus occidentalis

Brown pelican



Location North, Central, and South America, Caribbean
Status Least concern

Length 3¼–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
Weight Over 7¼ lb (3.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant



The brown pelican is mainly silver-gray and brown, with a white or white and yellow head and chestnut mane. The greenish skin of the face and throat pouch becomes much more vivid in the breeding season. The only pelican that feeds by plunge-diving instead of by swimming and fishing at the surface, it glides low over the water on outstretched wings, and on sighting a fish, flies up as high as 30 ft (10 m) before folding back its wings and plunging into the sea. It usually nests in trees or shrubs—often in mangroves.

However, the Peruvian pelican—a subspecies of the brown pelican—nests on the ground.



GROUP LIFE
Highly gregarious, the brown pelican roosts, migrates, and often feeds in groups. It also breeds colonially, on bare, low-lying islands.